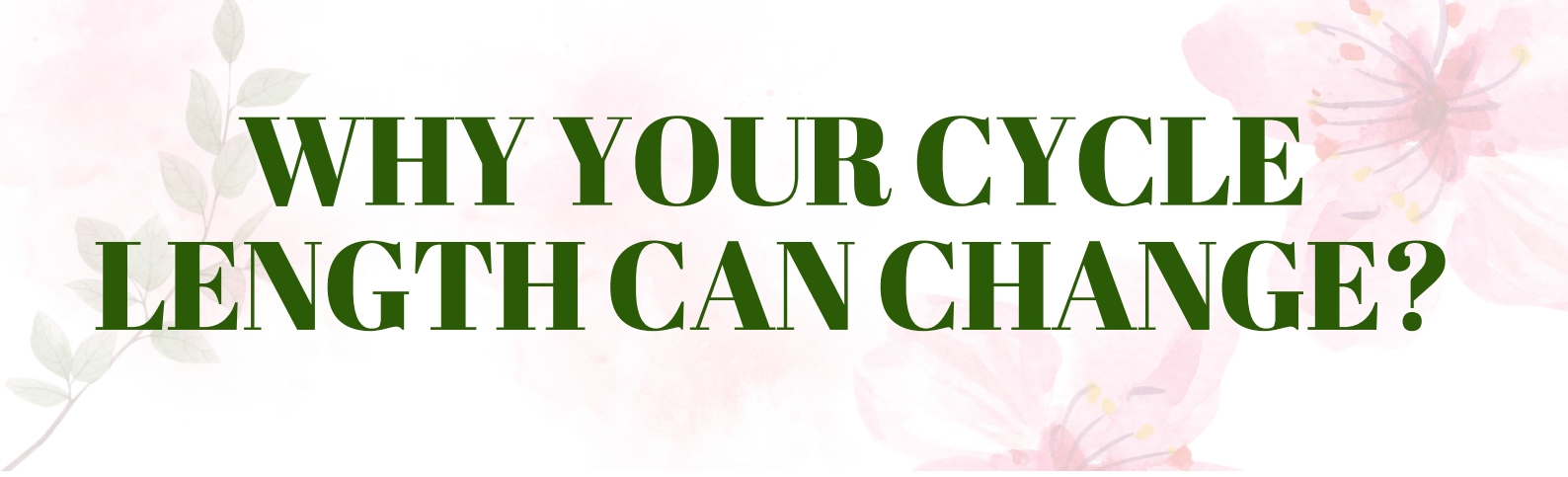




WHY YOUR CYCLE LENGTH CAN CHANGE?

A menstrual cycle does not always arrive on the exact same day every month. While many people think a normal cycle is always 28 days, healthy menstrual cycles can range from about 21 to 35 days.

This means that some variation is normal. However, when cycle changes become more noticeable, frequent, or severe, they may be considered irregular periods.

Irregular periods can include:

- Periods that come fewer than 21 days apart
- Periods that come more than 35 days apart
- Missing three or more periods in a row
- Bleeding that is much heavier or lighter than usual
- Periods lasting longer than seven days
- Bleeding between periods

Why Does Cycle Length Change?

Cycle length can change for many reasons. The menstrual cycle is controlled by hormones, so anything that affects hormone balance can also affect the timing of a period.

Sometimes these changes are temporary. In other cases, they may point to an underlying health condition.

Common Causes of Irregular Periods

- Stress
- Weight changes
- Intense exercise
- Hormonal conditions such as PCOS or thyroid disorders

- Reproductive health conditions such as endometriosis or PID
- Medications and birth control
- Pregnancy or breastfeeding

When Irregular Periods Are More Common

Irregular periods are more common during certain stages of life, including:

- The first few years after menstruation begins
- The years leading up to menopause

During these times, hormone levels may fluctuate more, which can make cycles less predictable.

When to Pay Attention

It is a good idea to speak with a healthcare provider if you notice:

- Missing periods for three months or longer
- Very heavy bleeding
- Severe pain or cramping
- Bleeding between periods
- Periods lasting longer than seven days
- Sudden major changes after previously regular cycles

Why Tracking Your Cycle Helps

Tracking your period can help you notice changes in:

- Cycle length
- Bleeding duration
- Flow heaviness
- Pain or other symptoms

This information can be useful for understanding your body and for sharing accurate details with a healthcare provider if concerns arise.

Key Takeaway

Not every cycle will be exactly the same, and some variation is normal. Cycle length can change because of stress, weight changes, exercise, hormonal shifts, medical conditions, or medications.

The most important thing is to notice patterns. If changes become frequent, severe, or unusual for you, it may be time to seek medical advice.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

*Educational content informed by Cleveland Clinic. (2023). Irregular Periods.
American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. Abnormal Uterine Bleeding.
U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Office on Women's Health. Menstrual Cycle.*